This wasn’t science fiction, or even a rom com. It was a kitchen-sink drama, coming to a climax. We were lucky with the rain in Manchester and won a tight Test in Durham through Stuart Broad’s personal momentum. His six-wicket spell, following a heated dressing-room row at tea sparked by Matty Prior’s scathing summary of declining standards, was decisive.

My form had certainly cooled, and I felt I had to take the lead by speaking passionately and harshly about what we were in danger of losing, without allowing emotions to contaminate relationships. The draw at the Oval, when bad light intervened controversially to prevent a 4–0 series win, merely emphasized the unforgiving nature of international cricket.

What turned out to be a flawed selection, that of Simon Kerrigan, proved to be another sobering example of flying too close to the sun. I had first faced him for Lancashire two years earlier, when he struck me as a serious bowler in the making. He was competitive, skilful, knew his own game. He also had that stubborn, arrogant streak you look for in a player from whom much is expected.

Jimmy agreed with my instinctive conclusion that he was a goer. In that blunt Burnley way of his he described Kerrigan as ‘the first young spin bowler I’ve seen who knows what he is doing’. Perhaps we should have both paid greater attention to those whispering that he bowled too slowly to thrive at the highest level.

It would become critical, once he was psychologically damaged by Shane Watson in Australia’s warm-up game against the England Lions at Northampton the week before his senior debut. Watson is a fantastic cricketer, a brilliant batsman in the shorter forms of the game, and since the pressure was off, was able to unload. He scored only 45 but hit Kerrigan hard and consistently in the general direction of Milton Keynes.

The logic of Kerrigan’s selection, that we wanted a left-armer to turn the ball away from a right-handed batsman in spinning conditions, began to look shaky in the build-up, where he simply didn’t look the same bowler who, at first glance, exuded authority and self-belief. He seemed nervous, and though I was conscious of the danger of him bowling at Watson, it was unavoidable.

It was another of those sliding-doors moments. Had he made an immediate breakthrough the course of his career could have been drastically different. As it was, those eight wicketless overs, which went for fifty-three runs, are his solitary contribution to Test cricket. He was released by